European Commission -
Speech

Speech by President von der Leyen at the EP Plenary debate on the conclusions of the European Council meeting of 18 December 2025 and a stronger and more sovereign Europe amid rising geopolitical tensions and continuous threats to the rules-based order

Strasbourg, 21 January 2026

Thank you, Madam President, dear Roberta,

President Costa, dear António,

Honourable Members,

Let me start by conveying my deepest condolences to the families and friends of the train accident in Spain. Our thoughts are with them.

Since I last stood here in this Plenary, we have witnessed events that have shaken the world. From the nationwide protests – and repression – across Iran to the seizing of shadow fleet tankers in the North Atlantic. From the volatile situation around the Arctic and Greenland to the relentless bombing against Ukrainian civilians and infrastructure. From the tensions in the Middle East to the Indo-Pacific. All of this reflects a number of realities for Europe.

The first is a confirmation that the shift in the international order is not only seismic – but it is permanent. And the sheer speed of change far outstrips anything we have seen in decades. We now live in a world defined by raw power – whether economic or military, technological or geopolitical. And while many of us may not like it, we must deal with the world as it is now.

Which brings me to the second reality – and imperative – for Europe. And that is to speed up our push for independence. Whether on our economy or our security, whether on technology or democracy. We have to be in strong in shaping ourselves if we want to shape the world around us. In this increasingly lawless world Europe needs its own levers of power. We know them: A strong economy, a thriving Single Market and industrial base – one that can do business in different markets and can compete all around the world –, a strong innovation and technology capacity, united societies – with high levels of education, talent and health systems –, and above a real capacity to defend ourselves. This is what European independence is about. It is not about anyone else, and it is not driven by recent events. It is about a need and an opportunity for us to build a stronger Union. We were already moving in this direction, but the speed of change requires a new approach from Europe. We will need a departure from Europe's traditional caution – just like we did on energy or on recovering from the pandemic with NextGenerationEU. Or like we are doing now on defence – with SAFE, or on supporting Ukraine. The world is changing faster than our mindset. So our institutions, governments and societies – all of us – must transform the ways in which we think and act. And allow me to touch on a number of points which I believe are critical.

Starting with security, and in particular the situation in the Arctic. Greenland is not just a territory in a key region of the world map, a land rich in critical raw materials, a strategic outpost on emerging global sea routes. It is all of those things. But above all, Greenland is home to a free and sovereign people. It is a nation with its sovereignty and its right to territorial integrity. And the future of Greenland is only for Greenlanders to decide.

Honourable Members,

We do agree with our American friends on the need to ensure the security of the Arctic region. On this we are not only aligned, but we are working together – notably within the context of NATO. Finland, for example, is working with the US on icebreakers – a key piece of equipment in the context of operations in the High North. Or take the recent Danish-led Arctic Light exercise a few months ago in

the context of NATO. This was key to strengthening Allied readiness in the Arctic. We are aligned. We are working together. We share the same strategic assessment on Arctic Security. And this is why the threat of additional tariffs for security reasons is simply wrong. If we are now plunging into a dangerous downward spiral between allies, this would only embolden the very adversaries we are both so committed to keeping out of our strategic landscape.

Later this week, leaders will meet to discuss our response. We are at a crossroads. Europe prefers dialogue and solutions – but we are fully prepared to act, if necessary, with unity, urgency and determination.

But beyond this, we need our own strategic approach. This is why we are working on a package to support Arctic Security. The first pillar will be a massive European investment surge in Greenland. In particular to further support the local economy and infrastructure. This will build on what we have already done. Two years ago, before all of this happened, I was in Nuuk to open our first office there. And in the next European budget, we have already proposed to double our financial support to Greenland. But we must do more and do it faster.

Second point, we will work with the US and all partners on wider arctic security. In particular, I believe we should use our defence spending surge on Artic-ready equipment. And strengthen our security arrangements with partners such as the UK, Canada, Norway, Iceland and others.

Finally, I believe Europe itself needs to reassess its wider security strategy. This should look at what is needed to adjust to today's new realities. Many of you have worked on various national and European security strategies, some of them in the recent past. But the world has changed so fast, and Europe now has to change with it.

Honourable Members,

When it comes to security, it is more important than ever that we keep focusing on Ukraine. Because our European security – and our European independence – hinges on what happens next. It is now almost four years since Russian tanks rolled into Ukraine. Peace talks are now ongoing, and we are recognising the efforts the US in this region. But while these efforts intensify, so do Russia's attacks. So Europe will continue to support Ukraine in every way. And this is why it was so important that, in the last European Council, we agreed to jointly raise EUR 90 billion for Ukraine. Europe has taken clear responsibility for Ukraine's needs – both civilian and military. And these EUR 90 billion show our unfaltering commitment and solidarity, and we will stand with Ukraine until there is a just and lasting peace.

Honourable Members,

Allow me to briefly turn to our economy – and our need to reduce our dependencies here too. Because this is intrinsically linked. Trade inside our Single Market accounts for 55% of our GDP. Trade with the rest of the world is worth roughly 45% of our GDP. Our supply chains and derisking goals depend on trade. So trade matters more than ever. I just came back from Paraguay, where we signed a historic deal with Mercosur. Next week we will be in India, for another groundbreaking agreement. And negotiations are advancing with many others who want to do business with us. These deals will open massive opportunities for our businesses, they will create jobs here in Europe and they give us resilience and security of supply. Because, the more trading partners we have world-wide, the more independent we are. And that is exactly what we need. If we take Mercosur, which I know is hotly debated within this House, the deal secures our access to the raw materials our industry needs, and the benefits for European companies will be huge. Take the automotive sector – European exports to Mercosur can rise by EUR 20 billion, or 200%. We could look at chemicals, or machinery. Same effects. The deal with Mercosur will deliver huge gains for producers of dairy, wine, spirits, oil – and much more. At the same time, we have listened carefully to your concerns and to our farmers, and we have secured strong safeguards for our sensitive agri-food sectors. I believe this is a deal that will bring benefits across our economy, and across every Member State.

To conclude, this moment of global change is fraught with dangers and Europe must be ready to change even faster to become more independent for its own future. This will not be easy, it will require difficult decisions, and it will require to frame all of our work in the bigger picture. But I am deeply convinced that, together, we can achieve it.

Thank you. And long live Europe.

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